

Q How many diapers and sizes do we stock up on before the birth?

Your baby will need diapers from the beginning, but it is sensible to exercise a little caution over how many you buy. While it is tempting to stock up on bargain deals at the supermarket, you don't yet know how big your baby will be.

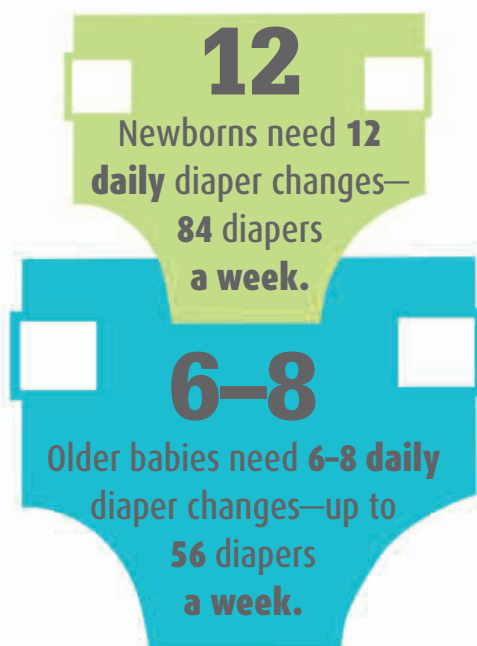
If you have a newborn on the larger size, she may spend very little time in newborn diapers. It may also take a while to figure out which brand you prefer, and which fit your baby best.

During the first week, the number of wet diapers your baby has each day will be about six, which amounts to 42 diapers or so. After the first week the number will gradually build up, and you can expect to change at least 10 to 12 wet diapers a day. So you may want to start off buying a couple of packages of newborn diapers to see you through the first week or so, and then assess whether you need to continue with a newborn size or move to the next size up. Some newborn diapers have a cut-out section to accommodate the umbilical cord stump, but you don't necessarily need these—you can just turn the diaper down at the front.

Reusable cloth diapers

If you plan to use reusables, you need around 20 diapers from the beginning, as well as washable wraps if you are using two-piece diapers with a cloth diaper and outer waterproof layer. There is a larger initial financial outlay

involved for cloth diapers, so unless you are sure you want your baby to wear reusables, you may prefer to wait until your daily routine has settled down and then look into the options.



CLOTH OR DISPOSABLE?

If you are undecided about which type of diaper to buy, consider these pros and cons:

» **Comfort:** disposables are more breathable, but their moisturizing, absorbing chemicals may irritate the skin. Cloth diapers may feel softer.

» **Convenience:** disposables are more convenient when out, at day care, or traveling. Cloth diapers aren't as absorbent, so you may need to change a dirty diaper more frequently. Nowadays, changing a diaper, whether disposable or cloth, is quick and easy.

» **Cost:** cloth diapers are usually cheaper than disposables unless you use a laundering service.

» **Other:** disposables use resources such as trees and plastics in the manufacturing process, then collect in landfills. Washing cloth diapers uses clean water and energy, but produces only dirty water. Disposables, however, reduce the risk of infection in a group setting such as a day-care center.

Disposable diapers
Although these are an easy choice, consider all options before you make a decision; you may opt to use a combination of both.



Q Aside from diapers, what else will we need for diaper changing?

You will need a wipe-clean baby changing mat, cotton balls or baby wipes to clean your baby's bottom, and diaper cream. Ideally use moistened cotton balls rather than baby wipes at home to avoid skin irritations, and use a diaper cream such as zinc oxide or petrolatum to prevent or ease any diaper rash. You may also like a purpose-made diaper disposal for disposable diapers. Used diapers are folded then placed in the chute, which seals them as the diaper moves down into the container, locking away odors. However, this is not essential and is an extra cost to be aware of. If you are using cloth diapers, you will need a bucket to store dirty ones before washing. These are purpose-made, or you can buy a normal lidded bucket.

Q Are there any other items we need for our baby's everyday care?

There are a few more essentials that you'll need to help to make life easier with a newborn.

A supply of burp cloths is very useful for protecting your clothing during burping, and some women also like to use these to cover up a little more when breast-feeding. A soft baby brush or comb will help to gently untangle knots when your baby's hair starts to grow, and baby scissors will keep her nails trim.

If your baby is born in the summer, you will also need some sunscreen to protect her from the sun's harmful rays. The general advice used to be to avoid putting sunscreen on babies under six months because chemicals in the sunscreen could irritate their delicate skin, and to keep them out of direct sunlight instead,

especially between 10am and 2pm. However, it's now recommended that as well as keeping your baby well covered and avoiding direct sunlight, you should also apply small amounts of sunscreen to exposed areas of skin. Buy at least SPF 30 with a four- or five-star rating that protects against both UVA and UVB rays. Also make sure that you have a wide-brimmed sun hat for her. When your baby is a little older, if you are going to the beach, you may want to invest in a bathing suit that covers her arms and legs, offering effective protection against UV rays.

If you want peace of mind about your baby while she sleeps, a baby monitor is useful. You can buy audio devices, with a transmitter placed next to your sleeping baby and a speaker near you; audio with motion sensor pads, which sound an alarm if your baby doesn't move for a while; and video monitors that allow you to both hear and see your baby.